HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE



"I've done something innovative"

Vishwas Nakhwa comes from a family with deep roots in the fishing industry. Facing a pressing need for ice to keep his catch fresh, he decided to diversify into a related venture. "I zeroed in on the idea of starting an ice factory," says Nakhwa, who owns four fishing trawlers. Each trawler requires 15 tonnes of ice per trip to preserve the catch from the moment it's netted at sea until its sale in wholesale markets. With boats typically at sea for up to a fortnight, reliable ice supply is crucial.

Nakhwa learned about PMMSY through officials at the Alibaug office of Maharashtra's fisheries department. He applied for a subsidy under his wife Roma's name, securing 60 per cent (Rs 90 lakh) of the approved project cost of Rs 1.5 crore. Commissioned last year, the factory has a production capacity of 50 tonnes per day.

VISHWAS DATTA NAKHWA, 48
Bodni, Raigad district, Maharashtra

Besides meeting the needs of his trawlers, Nakhwa also supplies ice to local trawlers and the fishermen's cooperative society. "Raigad district doesn't have many ice plants. Earlier, we had to transport ice from Mumbai, which took 3-4 hours. Now, we can get it from my factory," he says. The plant also provides employment for eight workers.

While market rates for ice range between Rs 1,500 and Rs 1,600 per tonne, Nakhwa offers it at a lower price of Rs 1,200 to Rs 1,300. "What warms my heart is that I've done something innovative," he adds. ■

components, such as deep-sea fishing vessels, harbours, fish-landing hubs, advanced wholesale and retail markets, fish feed plants and a robust cold chain—essential for preserving seafood from sea to fork—remain underdeveloped. The cold chain, which includes the supply of block ice for fishing trawlers and tube ice for processing facilities, is particularly crucial given seafood's perishable nature. Yet, ice shortages during the peak fishing season (September to December) drive up prices and disrupt operations. The quality of seafood directly determines its market price. In the absence of proper cold storage or refrigerated transportation, its value diminishes quickly.

THE EASE OF LIVING

Enter the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY), a game-changer for India's fisherfolk. By injecting vital infrastructure and financial support, the scheme is not only addressing their long-standing challenges but is also empowering approximately 600,000 fishing families, helping them secure better livelihoods and improved incomes.

Key initiatives include the development of 27,189 transportation facilities, 1,091 fish feed plants, 922 hatcheries, and 480 deep-sea fishing vessels, increasing fish production from 13.75 million tonnes (MT) in FY19 to a projected 22 MT by FY25. These are helping fisherfolk overcome logistical challenges, reduce post-harvest losses and improve market access.

"Infrastructure like cold storages, insulated vans, hatcheries and oriental fish units were lacking," says a senior official from the Maharashtra fisheries department. "The subsidies through PMMSY have given a boost to their creation." Maharashtra alone has approved over Rs 1,400 crore in subsidies for 4,174 beneficiaries, funding projects such as reservoir cage farming, biofloc ponds, fish feed mills and cold storage facilities. Women and Scheduled Caste and Tribe beneficiaries get a 60 per cent subsidy, while others are eligible for 40 per cent.

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A food processing entrepreneur from the state, who received a refrigerated van under the scheme, says: "The van has enabled me to process, store and export shrimp while maintaining the cold chain. It ensures premium quality and fetches a good value for my produce." Such interventions not only enhance incomes but also reduce wastage and open up export opportunities. The scheme also emphasises cooperative efforts, with Maharashtra's 1,200 fishing cooperatives playing a critical role in implementing projects.

The initiatives have strengthened the fisheries value chain, ensuring fisherfolk benefit from sustainable and modern practices. By bridging gaps in production, technology and infrastructure, PMMSY is enhancing the economic resilience of fisherfolk and improving their quality of life. ■